

Judge Navi Pillay Wins the Nobel Peace Prize

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Navi Pillay, a judge and human rights lawyer from South Africa, has won the 2026 **Nobel Peace Prize**. It was announced on Friday.

The Nobel Committee called her a "legal pioneer" with great courage. It said it chose her at a time when "institutions of **international law** are under political attack." **International law** is the set of rules countries agree to follow.

Pillay grew up in South Africa under **apartheid**, a system that treated people unfairly because of their race. She faced unfair treatment but rose to the top of the legal world.

She is now a judge on the International Court of Justice, a United Nations court. She once led the UN's human rights office. She was also a judge at the International Criminal Court and at a court for crimes from the 1994 **genocide** in Rwanda.

Stephen Rapp, a former US official, said her work always respected victims and survivors.

Hours after the prize was announced, the US government put **sanctions** on the International Criminal Court.

Word Treasure

Nobel Peace Prize -- A famous award given each year to someone who works for peace.

international law -- Rules that countries agree to follow.

apartheid -- An old system in South Africa that treated people unfairly because of their race.

genocide -- An attempt to destroy a whole group of people.

sanctions -- Penalties a government uses to pressure a country or group.

Background you need

The Nobel Peace Prize is one of the world's most famous awards, given to people who work for peace.

International courts are places where countries settle arguments or where people are put on trial for very serious crimes.

Break it down

WHO: Navi Pillay, a judge and human rights lawyer from South Africa

WHAT: She won the 2026 Nobel Peace Prize

WHERE: Announced on Friday; she works in world courts, including a United Nations court

WHY: The Nobel Committee praised her courage as a legal pioneer when international law is under attack

Why it matters

Pillay's story shows that someone who was treated unfairly as a child can grow up to help protect the rights of people around the world.

Test what you remember

1. What prize did Navi Pillay win?

- ☐ (A) A science prize
- ☐ (B) A film award
- ☐ (C) An Olympic medal
- ☐ (D) The Nobel Peace Prize

2. Where is Pillay from?

- ☐ (A) Germany
- ☐ (B) Rwanda
- ☐ (C) The United States
- ☐ (D) South Africa

3. What did the Nobel Committee call her?

- ☐ (A) A famous singer
- ☐ (B) A great athlete
- ☐ (C) A legal pioneer
- ☐ (D) A world leader

4. What was apartheid?

- ☐ (A) A kind of court
- ☐ (B) A city in Africa
- ☐ (C) A system that treated people unfairly because of their race
- ☐ (D) A peace prize

5. Which court is Pillay a judge on now?

- ☐ (A) A school court
- ☐ (B) The International Court of Justice
- ☐ (C) The US Supreme Court
- ☐ (D) A sports court

6. What did the US do hours after the prize was announced?

- ☐ (A) Held an election
- ☐ (B) Put sanctions on the International Criminal Court
- ☐ (C) Gave Pillay a medal
- ☐ (D) Closed the United Nations

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: C 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Nobel Committee: Calls Pillay a legal pioneer with great courage.
2. Stephen Rapp, former US official: Says her work always respected victims and survivors.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):